

TEN WAYS TO MINIMIZE KID-SPENDING MADNESS

Whether you're a single mom on a tight budget or a stepdad trying to feed his tribe, there are plenty of ways to save money with kids in the house. Make it into a game—one the whole family can play. Draw up a chart, put it up in the kitchen and have your kids mark down all the times they save a buck or two.

Here are some tried-and-true ways to cut down on costs. Remember: every penny counts.

1. **Don't cut corners, cut hair.** When your kids are young, they don't care about having the hippest new 'do—they just need the hair out of their eyes. So be the barber for your family and you'll save money. Take a few classes or watch a YouTube video. Bonus: you'll score a little extra bonding time when your kid's in the barber chair.
2. **Pick and choose your name brands.** When you go grocery shopping or to the pharmacy, you'll see a lot of name brands at a hefty markup. But more often than not, the store brand has *exactly* the same ingredients for half the price. Decide on the stuff you won't compromise on—for us, it's brand-name ketchup and paper towels—and then buy the store brand of everything else.
3. **Put toys on rotation.** If you're like most North American families, your living room, den and child's bedroom are clogged with toys. But no kid needs that many all the time—and wow, are those things expensive! When Savannah was small, Linda would sock some of her toys away and then, instead of buying her the new things when she got bored, Linda would take out the stashed ones. Savannah was